

for paying future education costs. Before you enlist (or reenlist), try to negotiate a better deal.

- **A no-down-payment mortgage.** If you've served 24 months of active duty and are now home (or you're currently on active duty and have been for at least 6 months), you can apply to have the Veterans Administration *guarantee* your home loan. You'll still have to apply for a normal mortgage with a bank or other lender, but because of the guarantee, your mortgage officer will waive all or part of the normal down payment requirement. National Guard and Reservists qualify for this benefit after six years of service. Unfortunately, with no down payment you'll end up paying more interest, so unless you have a very specific reason to want to buy a home right away, you should probably wait and try to build up a down payment of at least 10%.
- **Help in preventing foreclosure.** Lenders are not allowed to foreclose on your home for nine months after you return from duty. If you've been injured and cannot work, they may also not be able to take your home from you if you haven't yet received your disability money and need it to pay your mortgage. For help, try the nonprofit Operation Homefront (www.operationhomefront.net).
- **Inexpensive health care.** Those currently in the military and their immediate families can get free medical treatment on the base, or can pay a small annual premium (up to \$150 for individual coverage or \$300 for families) for other health plans that allow visits to civilian doctors. Those who've left the military can enroll in the VA health care system (although noncombat injuries will have low priority).
- **Special sources of insurance.** Active duty and former military personnel and their immediate families can purchase home and auto insurance through USAA (www.usaa.com) or Armed Forces Insurance (www.afi.org).
- **Tax-favored retirement savings.** You can voluntarily contribute to the Thrift Savings Program, which basically